

GREY CROWNED CRANE

Balearica regulorum

Grey crowned cranes belong to the Gruidae family of birds, famous for their choreography; for these birds, dance is an important part of life. On the open savanna they display by jumping, flapping their wings, and bowing – sometimes, it seems, just to relieve aggression or reinforce pair-bonding – but mainly to court their mate by flaunting their elaborate head ornamentation. They lack the long, coiled windpipe of the longer-billed crane species, so instead of calling like a bugle they honk like a goose. They also boom during courtship by puffing air from an inflated red throat sac. During the breeding season pairs retire to wetter habitats, where thicker vegetation conceals their nest – a circular platform made from grasses and sedges. Here, the chicks are hidden from predators, allowing the parents to roost, uniquely for cranes, perched high in trees.



SIZE 1.1 m (3½ ft)

HABITAT Open country

DISTRIBUTION E. and S. Africa

DIET Grasses, seeds, invertebrates, small vertebrates

black head feathers
give the appearance
of a bulging
forehead

THIRD EYELID >

Also known as a nictitating membrane, from the Latin *nictare*, meaning “to blink”, this translucent eyelid – the same as in other birds – moves across the eye to clean its surface.



GOLDEN PLUMES >

When the wings are folded, long, golden feathers on the upper wings – just above the flight feathers – hang down over the side of the body.



✓ RUFFLED NECK

Long, tapered contour feathers give the crowned crane a shaggy appearance around the upper part of the body and the lower part of the neck. Most of the bird's plumage is grey.



nostril

bill is shorter and
stouter than in other
crane species

FEET AND CLAWS >

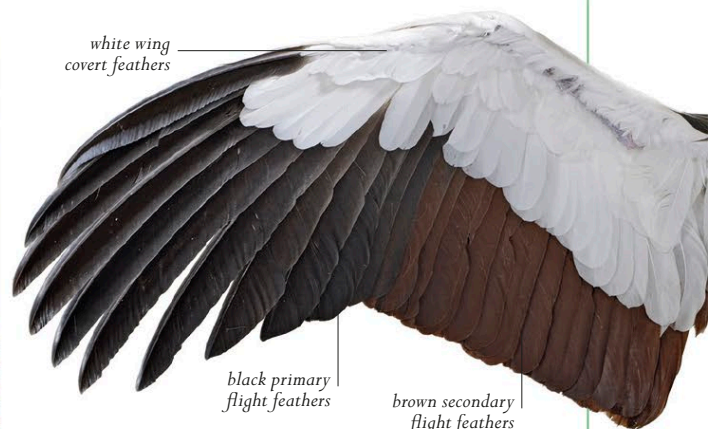
Crowned cranes have long hind toes, setting them apart from other crane species. This enables them to perch in trees – perhaps a vestige of tree-dwelling ancestors.



^ LONG LEGS

Although long legs help in dancing displays, and are good for wading, crowned cranes have shorter legs than those of other crane species.

white wing
covert feathers



black primary
flight feathers

brown secondary
flight feathers

^ WING

When crowned cranes fly overhead, their white under-wing patches are clearly visible. Although strong-winged, these tropical birds – unlike other cranes – do not sustain long-distance migrations.